

not click with his viewers any more. "Our audiences have moved beyond the saas-bahu stories and want to see the positive side of the woman-next-door. We don't have snazzy clothes and spiffy sets and even our vamps are not ultra-sexy," he says.

In *Kolangal* and *Rangoli*, the protagonist is a middle-class working woman and the story is based on her responsibilities and the problems in life. Live, outdoor locations are yet another hook to draw viewers, explains Srinivisan, whose crew often shoots outside the sets or even overseas. "Add lots of emotions and drama to a simple family setting and viewers will connect immediately," adds S. Siddiq, producer of the hit soap *Minnukettu*. The Gaayathri Priya-starrer, *Minnukettu*, which is ruling Malayalam prime time with TRPs of about 12, is an emotional family drama about a man and his five daughters.

The formula seems to have worked

wonders on the Marathi screen as well. Popular soaps like *Asambhav* and *Ya Sukhano Ya* are set in middle-class homes with little emphasis on costumes and looks. "Our serials reflect Maharashtrian culture and sensibilities which any regular viewer can relate to," insists Swati Thanawala, associate producer of Rahul Productions, which produces *Ya Sukhano Ya* and *Vahinisaheb*. While the former deals with the conflicting ambitions of three brothers, *Vahinisaheb* is a peek into a conservative zamindar household and the power play between the characters. Director of Zee Regionals, Nitin Vaidya, explains that the themes and presentation of these regional serials differ from their Hindi counterparts. "Our target audience is the entire state and not just the affluent urban viewer. So we depict a setting and stories that are close to them," he says.

So, pancake faces and chandelier costumes are replaced by simple

sarees and sparsely furnished homes to maximise the woman-next-door effect. Ravi Ojha, producer of the popular Bangla daily soap *Khela* believes that regional television is high on content, a factor national Hindi programming lacks in. "We draw heavily from literature which makes our ideas richer," he explains. *Khela*, he says, is the story of two women who are in love with the same man. Ojha has produced popular Hindi serials for Doordarshan like *Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi* and *Wagle Ki Duniya* but shifted to the Bengali screen "which offers more creative freedom".

The immense popularity of these soaps is prompting producers to recreate the success story in other languages as well. "Dubbed versions do not do as well as remakes as they give the serial a more indigenous look," says Siddiq who remade his hit Tamil show *Mettioli* as *Maangalya* in Kannada and *Minnukettu* in Malayalam. "Also, regional television is popular because people like to see stories in their own language although the productions are relatively low budget," adds Ojha.

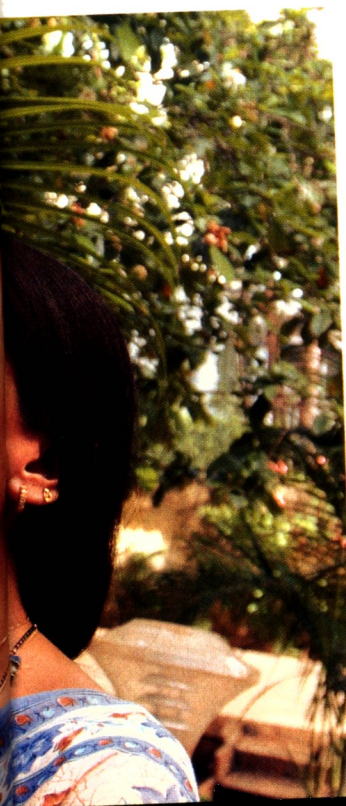
But the market is growing quite steadily. Says Vaidya, "The Marathi channel revenue is expected to cross Rs 150 crore this year, which is almost double the figure four years ago. Even the advertising rates are much higher now". Watch any prime time regional show and you will see automobiles,

FMCGs and white goods vying for the upwardly mobile consumer's attention.

The growth, however, is not reflected in the actors' salaries. A huge gap exists in their remuneration—while the lead actors of the regional screen get approximately Rs 7,000 for a day's shoot, their Hindi counterparts command Rs 2 to 5 lakh. Ojha sounds a warning bell: "Television is fast becoming corporate driven. If something works, people think that is the formula and don't want to experiment." Maybe it's time for the regional screen to diversify the dramatics before it gets back into the saas-bahu mode. ■

CROWD

Exit Tulsi, goodbye Parvati. The sagas of middle-class women triumph over chandelier sarees and pancake faces on regional television



◀ **GAAYATHRI PRIYA, GANGA IN MINNUKETTU,** plays the nerve centre of a family of five sisters in the Malayalam soap.